Behind the Staff Room Door – A Collection

By Brian Moses, Bruce Lansky, Darren Sardelli and Bill Dodds

Targets by Brian Moses (Pg 132)

My teacher says my targets are:
To write more neatly,
to spell more words correctly,
to get more sums right,
to chatter less,
and to behave myself.

But the targets I set myself
are far more interesting:

To climb a tree to the top,
to stop time before my spelling test,
to think up a disappearing spell
and try it out on my teacher,
to leap from up high
and to defy gravity.

These are my targets,
the ones I'm aiming to complete
before next week . . .

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The ones my teacher sets
may take a little longer . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Brian Moses (all poems by this author)
Book: Lost Magic – The Very Best of Brian Moses
ISBN: 978-1509838745
Publisher: Macmillan Children's Books
Date (Month/Year): Dec 2016

INTRODUCTION

When you are little, your brain tries to make sense of the world as you experience it. Magic is real and logic is relative. For example, when I was little, I honestly believed that teachers actually lived at the school and were specially modified to never have to go to the bathroom. Their personal rooms, kind of like dorm rooms, were behind the door marked "Teacher's Lounge." I mean, what other explanation was there?

I present today, education from a kid's perspective in. Behind the Staff Room Door – A Collection with poems by Brian Moses, Bruce Lansky, Darren Sardelli and Bill Dods

Behind the Staffroom Door by Brian Moses (Pg 135-136)

Ten tired teachers slumped in the staffroom at playtime,
one collapsed when the coffee ran out, then there were nine.

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Nine tired teachers making lists of things they hate,
one remembered playground duty, then there were eight.

Eight tired teachers thinking of holidays in Devon,
one slipped off to pack his case, then there were seven.

Seven tired teachers, weary of children's tricks,
one hid in the stock cupboard, then there were six.

Six tired teachers, under the weather, barely alive,
one gave an enormous sneeze, then there were five.

Five tired teachers, gazing at the open door,
one made a quick getaway, then there were four.

Four tired teachers, faces lined with misery,
one locked herself in the ladies, then there were three.

Three tired teachers, wondering what to do,
one started screaming when the bell rang, then there were two.

Two tired teachers, thinking life really ought to be fun,
one was summoned to see the Head, then there was one.

One tired teacher caught napping in the afternoon sun,
fled quickly from the staffroom, then there were none.

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How to Torture Your Teacher by Bruce Lansky (Pg 38-39)

Only raise your hand when
you want to sharpen your pencil
or go to the bathroom.
Repeat every ten minutes.

Never raise your hand
when you want to answer a question;
instead, yell, “Oooh! Oooh! Oooh!”
and then, when the teacher calls on you,
say, “I forgot what I was going to say.”

Lean your chair back,
take off your shoes, and
put your feet up on your desk.
Act surprised when the teacher
puts all four legs of your chair back on the floor.

Drop the eraser end of your pencil
on your desk.
See how high it will bounce.

Drop your books on the floor
See how loud a noise you can make.

Hum.
Get all your friends to join in.

Hold your nose,
make a face, and say, “P.U.!”

Fan the air away from your face,
and point to the kid in front of you.

On the last day of school,
lead your classmates in chanting:
“No more pencils!
No more books!
No more teachers’
dirty looks!”

Then, on your way out
the door, tell the teacher,
“Bet you’re looking forward
to summer vacation this year.
But I’ll sure miss you.
You’re the best teacher
I’ve ever had.”

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Bruce Lansky
Book: No More Homework! No More Tests!
ISBN: 978-0671577025
Publisher: Running Press Adult
Date (Month/Year): Aug 1997

Billy’s Coming Back by Brian Moses (Pg 123-124)

Word is out on the street,
Billy's coming back.

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There's a sound outside of running feet,
somebody, somewhere's switched on the heat,
policemen are beating a swift retreat
now Billy's coming back.

Only last year when he went away
everyone heaved a sigh,
now news is out, and the neighborhood
is set to blow sky-high.

Words are heard in the staff room,
teachers' faces deepen with gloom,
can't shrug off this feeling of doom,
now Billy's coming back.

It was wonderful when he upped and left,
a carnival feeling straightaway,
no looking over shoulders,
each day was a holiday.

And now like a bomb, no one dares to defuse,
time ticks on while kids quake in their shoes
no winners here, you can only lose,
now Billy's coming back.

It's dog eat dog on the street tonight,
it's cat and mouse, Billy's looking for a fight,
so take my advice, keep well out of sight
now Billy's coming back.

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Silliest Teacher in School by Darren Sardelli (Pg 5)

Our teacher gave detention
to the fountains in the hall.
She handed extra homework
to the artwork on the wall.

We saw her point a finger
at a banner and a sign.
She said their bad behavior
was completely out of line.

The principal approached her
and said, "What is all this fuss?
I heard you tried to punish
all the tires on a bus.

"You've made the teachers angry
by disrupting all their classes,
so if you want to keep this job,
you have to wear your glasses!"

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Darren Sardelli
Book: Galaxy Pizza and Meteor Pie
ISBN: 978-0615284699
Publisher: Laugh-A-Lot Books
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2009

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TRANSITION

We had recess and story time. Elementary schools was MARVELOUS! Until the day your beloved teacher didn't appear. You know what that means . . . a substitute!(sad face, rapidly changing to mischievous)

YAY! Chaos! -- switching names, pretending you get 5 recesses instead of 3; telling the poor soul that "that's not the way Mrs. Smith does it!" all day long. Well, that's what usually happens (beat) unless your substitute is (maniacal laugh and evil teacher face) Mrs. Stein . . .

Mrs. Stein by Bill Dodds (Pg 48-51)

The school bell rings, we go inside,
Our teacher isn't there.
"Maybe she's sick!" her pet cries out.
Yeah, right. As if I'd care.

I have a D in Language Arts,
My grade in math's the same.
And now my teacher might be sick.
Could be I'm part to blame.

She doesn't like me, that's a fact,
I wouldn't tell a lie.
She says stuff like: "You're very smart,
But you don't even try."

I start to laugh—my teacher's sick!
And boy, I'm feeling fine . . .

When someone knocks the door right in,
And there stands Frankenstein.

She's six-foot-eight, her dress is black,
She's wearing combat boots.
I start to gasp, she growls and says,
"I'll be your substitute."

The teacher's pet is whimpering;
She doesn't stand a chance.
The smart kid stares and points and faints.
The bully wets his pants.

"My name is Mrs. Stein," she says,
And every student cringes.
She leans the door against the wall,
She's knocked it off its hinges.

"Now let's begin. You there! Stand up!"
She looks me in the eye.
I try to move, my legs won't work.
I know I'm going to die!

In one big step she's next to me,
And she does more than hover.
She blocks the sun, it's dark as night,
My classmates run for cover.

"Now get up to the board," she says.
"I'd like to see some action.

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Pick up the chalk, explain to us
Division of a fraction."

I leap away to save my life,
This time I really try.
I think and think and think and croak,
"Invert and multiply."

"Correct! She says. I breathe again
And head back for my chair.
"You, FREEZE!" she shouts, and I stop cold.
"And don't go anywhere."

This all begins at nine o'clock,
I fight to stay alive.
It seems to last a million years—
The clock says nine-o-five.

That's just three hundred seconds,
And then my turn is through.
She points at every one of us—
"Now you. Now, you. Now, you."

We all get nailed this awful day,
There's nowhere we can hide.
The lunch bell rings, we cannot eat,
We simply crawl outside.

We can't believe the other kids
Who run and play their games.

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Not us, who have big Mrs. Stein—
Our world is not the same.

The bell has tolled, I must go in,
My time on earth is through.
I'll leave this on the playground—
Here's what you have to do.

You must listen to your teacher
And pray her health is fine,
Or one day soon you'll hear the words:
"My name is Mrs. Stein."

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Bill Dodds
Book: Kids Pick the Funniest Poems: Poems that Make Kids Laugh (Edited by Bruce Lansky) Pgs 48-51
ISBN: 978-0671747695
Publisher: Meadowbrook
Date (Month/Year): Nov 1991

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